

Two Ways of Seeing a River

Mark Twain

1[1] The face of the water, in time, **became** a wonderful book—a book **that was** a dead language to the **uneducated** passenger, but **which** told its mind to me without reserve, **delivering** its most cherished secrets as clearly **as if it uttered** them with a voice.

[2] And it **was** not a book to be read once and thrown aside, for it **had** a new story to tell every day.

[3] Throughout the long twelve hundred miles there **was** never a page **that was** void of interest, never one **that you could leave** unread without loss, never one **that you would want** to skip, thinking you **could find** higher enjoyment in some other thing.

[4] There never **was** so wonderful a book written by man; never one **whose** interest **was** so absorbing, so unflagging, so sparkingly renewed with every re-perusal.

[5] The passenger **who** could not read it **was** charmed with a **peculiar** sort of faint dimple on its surface (on the rare occasions **when** he **did not overlook** it altogether); but to the pilot that **was** an italicized passage; indeed, it **was** more than that, it **was** a legend of the largest capitals, with a string of shouting exclamation points at the end of it; for it **meant** that a wreck or a rock **was** buried there **that could tear** the life out of the strongest vessel **that ever floated**.

[6] It **is** the faintest and simplest expression **the water ever makes**, and the most hideous to a pilot's eye.

[7] In truth, the passenger ^{定语从句} who could not read this book saw nothing but all manner of pretty pictures in it, painted by the sun and shaded by the clouds, ^{对比状语从句} whereas to the trained eye these were not pictures at all, but the grimmest and most dead-earnest of reading matter.

2[8] Now ^{时间状语从句} when I had mastered the language of this water and had come to know every trifling feature ^{定语从句} that bordered the great river as familiarly ^{比较状语从句} as I knew the letters of the alphabet, I had made a valuable acquisition.

[9] But I had lost something, too.

[10] I had lost something ^{定语从句} which could never be restored to me ^{时间状语从句} while I lived.

[11] All the grace, the beauty, the poetry had gone out of the majestic river!

[12] I still keep in mind a certain wonderful sunset ^{定语从句} which I witnessed ^{时间状语从句} when steamboating was new to me.

[13] A broad **expanse** of the river **was turned** to blood; in the middle distance the red **hue** **brightened** into gold, **through which** a solitary log **came** floating, black and **conspicuous**; in one place a long, **slanting** mark **lay** sparkling upon the water; in another the **surface** **was** broken by boiling, **tumbling** rings, **that were** as **many-tinted** as an **opal**; **where** the **ruddy flush** **was** faintest, **was** a smooth spot **that was covered** with graceful circles and **radiating** lines, ever so **delicately** traced; the shore on our left **was** densely wooded, and the **somber shadow** **that fell** from this forest **was** broken in one place by a long, **ruffled** trail **that shone** like silver; and high above the forest wall a **clean-stemmed** dead tree **waved** a single leafy bough **that glowed** like a flame in the **unobstructed** **splendor** **that was** flowing from the sun.

[14] There **were** graceful curves, reflected images, woody heights, soft distances; and over the whole scene, far and near, the **dissolving** lights **drifted** steadily, enriching it, every passing moment, with new marvels of coloring.

3[15] I **stood** like one **bewitched**.

[16] I **drank** it in, in a speechless **rapture**.

[17] The world **was** new to me, and I **had** never **seen** anything like this at home.

[18] But **as** I **have said**, a day **came** **when** I **began** to **cease from** noting the glories and the charms **which** the moon and the sun and the **twilight** **wrought upon** the river's face; another day **came** **when** I **ceased** altogether to note them.

[19] Then, **if** that sunset scene **had been repeated**, I **should have looked upon** it without rapture, **and should have commented upon** it, inwardly, after this fashion: This sun **means** **that** we **are going to have** wind tomorrow; that floating log **means** **that** the river **is rising**, small thanks to it; that slanting mark on the water **refers** to a bluff reef **which is going to kill** somebody's steamboat one of these nights, **if it keeps on stretching out** like that; those tumbling "boils" **show** a dissolving bar and a changing channel there; the lines and circles in the slick water over yonder **are** a warning **that** that troublesome place **is shoaling up** dangerously; that silver streak in the shadow of the forest **is** the "break" from a new snag, and he **has located** himself in the very best place **he could have found** to fish for steamboats; that tall dead tree, with a single living branch, **is not going to last** long, and then how **is** a body ever **going to get through** this blind place at night without the friendly old landmark.

(that)

4[20] No, the romance and the beauty **were** all gone from the river.

(that)

[21] All the value any feature of it **had** for me now **was** the amount of usefulness it **could furnish** toward **compassing** the safe piloting of a steamboat.

(that)

[22] Since those days, I **have pitied** doctors from my heart.

[23] What **does** the lovely flush in a beauty's cheek **mean** to a doctor but a "break" **that ripples** above some deadly disease

[24] **Are** not all her visible charms sown thick with **what are** to him the signs and symbols of hidden decay?

[25] **Does** he ever **see** her beauty at all, or **doesn't** he simply **view** her professionally, and **comment upon** her unwholesome condition all to himself?

[26] And **doesn't** he sometimes **wonder** **whether** he **has gained** most or **lost** most by learning his trade?

(has)